

VEER

Family Life

Homework, hard conversations, caring for a parent, and the admin nobody wants.

You are here

By the end of this guide you'll be able to:

Help with homework in a way that teaches, with a clear line you don't cross.

Explain something to a child when you've realised you can't.

Practise a hard conversation before you have it.

Keep track of caring for a parent without holding it all in your head.

Walk into a medical appointment with the right questions written down.

Plan a trip that several people can actually live with.

Get on top of family admin — the forms, the dates, the paperwork.

Some of this book is light. Some of it is about the hardest year you'll have. Both are here on purpose.

01

Homework that teaches instead of answering

Let's deal with this first and plainly, because everything else in the chapter depends on where the line sits.

Claude can do your child's homework. It should not, and this book won't help you do that.

Not for a moral lecture's sake — for a practical reason.

Homework isn't the point. The point is the thinking the homework produces. Work that gets handed in without that thinking has cost your child the lesson and bought a mark that means nothing.

There's a second reason. Your child's school has rules about this, and those rules are the authority here, not this book. If you don't know what they are, ask.

The line, stated once:

Yes · Explaining a concept until it lands. Three different ways if needed.

Yes · Working through a *similar* problem, step by step, while your child watches.

Yes · Asking your child questions to find where they're stuck.

Yes · Checking finished work and pointing at what's wrong without saying why.

Never · Producing anything that gets handed in.

THE TEST THAT SETTLES EVERY BORDERLINE CASE

Afterwards, can your child explain it to you in their own words? If yes, they learned it. If no, something did the work for them — and it doesn't matter how it was phrased.

Try this now. Find out what your child's school actually says about this. That's the first step, before any of the rest.

02

The homework script

The difference between tutoring and answering is entirely in how you ask. Three sentences change the whole behaviour.

THE SETUP, EVERY TIME

My daughter is nine and stuck on long division. Explain it the way a patient teacher would, using a different example from the one she's been set. Don't solve her actual problem. Ask her questions as you go to check she's following.

Three things are doing the work: her age, *a different example*, and *ask her questions*.

WHEN THEY'RE STUCK AND YOU CAN'T TELL WHY

Ask my son questions about this topic, one at a time, until you find the specific thing he's misunderstood. Don't explain anything until you've found it.

CHECKING FINISHED WORK

Here's what she's written. Point out anything that's wrong or missing, but don't correct it — tell me what to ask her so she finds it herself.

WHEN THEY'VE LOST HEART

My son thinks he's the only one who doesn't get this. Explain it very simply, be encouraging without being patronising, and start with something he's likely to already know.

Try this now. Use the setup ask on something they're working on. Sit with them while it runs.

03

When your child asks you something you don't know

Children ask questions adults can't answer. Why is the sky blue, how do aeroplanes stay up, what happens when you die, why do people go to prison.

The instinct is to bluff or deflect. Neither works — children detect both.

Turn it into something you do together. *Let's find out* is a better answer than a wrong one, and it teaches something more useful than the fact.

TOGETHER, AT THE KITCHEN TABLE

My seven-year-old has asked me why the sky is blue and I've realised I can't actually explain it. Explain it so she'd understand, using something in a kitchen as the comparison. Then give me one question I can ask to check she followed it.

Ask for the comparison to be something in the room. Abstract explanations bounce off children; concrete ones stick.

Ask for the follow-up question. It turns a fact into a conversation, and it tells you whether it landed.

For the hard ones, say what you want to convey and what you'd rather avoid.

FOR A DIFFICULT SUBJECT

My six-year-old has asked why her grandfather died. Help me explain it honestly, in words she'll understand, without frightening her. We're not religious. Keep it short — she'll ask more when she's ready.

YOU'RE ALLOWED TO NOT KNOW

Saying "I don't know, let's find out" in front of a child is one of the more useful things you can model. Children who never see an adult not know grow up thinking not knowing is shameful.

Try this now. Think of the last question you fudged. Go back and do it properly.

04

Practising a hard conversation

Some conversations you get one attempt at. Telling a teenager something they don't want to hear. Raising driving with an elderly parent. Saying the thing that's been unsaid for two years.

You can rehearse those now, which was never possible before, and it makes a real difference.

REHEARSAL

I need to talk to my seventeen-year-old about staying out without telling us where he is. I want to keep his trust, not win an argument. Play him — respond the way a defensive teenager actually would — and let me practise.

Ask it to be difficult. A rehearsal where the other person is reasonable teaches you nothing. *Push back the way they actually would.*

Then ask what you're getting wrong.

THE DEBRIEF

Based on how I just handled that, what am I doing that will make him defensive? What should I say differently?

And prepare, rather than script. A memorised speech collapses at the first unexpected reply. What survives is knowing your two or three points and the outcome you want.

FOR THE DRIVING CONVERSATION

Help me prepare to talk to my father about giving up driving. He's proud and this will feel like a loss of independence. Ask me questions about him first, then help me work out how to open it.

Try this now. Rehearse the conversation you've been avoiding. Ask it to be difficult.

05

Caring for a parent

The load here is rarely one big thing. It's forty small ones — appointments, medications, forms, who said what, which brother is doing what — and the exhausting part is holding them all in your head at once.

Say all of it out loud and let it come back organised.

THE BRAIN-DUMP

I'm helping look after my mother, who's eighty-four and increasingly forgetful. I'll describe everything I'm currently juggling in no particular order. Turn it into something organised, and tell me what I've probably forgotten.

That last clause is the valuable one. People in the middle of this are too close to see the gap.

Keep a running record. After a phone call, an appointment, a change — describe it and ask for it written up plainly. Months later, that record is the thing you'll be glad of.

AFTER ANYTHING HAPPENS

Here's what happened at today's appointment, roughly as I remember it. Write it up clearly with the date, what was decided, and what I need to do next.

Divide the work explicitly. *Help me write out who's doing what, so I can send it to my brother and sister* converts a resentment into a document.

THIS IS NOT MEDICAL OR LEGAL ADVICE

Use this to organise, remember, and prepare. Medication, diagnosis, care decisions, and anything involving money or legal authority go to the professionals involved — and to the rest of your family.

Try this now. Describe everything you're carrying, unstructured. Ask what you've forgotten.

06

Talking to a parent's doctor

Medical appointments are short, and people leave them realising they asked none of the things they meant to. Preparation solves most of that.

Before: write the questions down.

BEFORE YOU GO

I'm taking my father to a hospital appointment about his memory. I'll describe what we've noticed over the past year. Help me write a short list of what to tell them, and the questions worth asking. Order them, because we may not get through them all.

Asking for them ordered is the trick. Ten minutes rarely covers ten questions.

Afterwards: make sense of what was said.**AFTER YOU GET HOME**

Here's what I remember from the appointment, including the bits I didn't follow. Explain what it means in plain English, and tell me what I should have asked so I can raise it next time.

Keep a symptom timeline. Clinicians ask when something started and whether it's changed, and nobody remembers under pressure. A written timeline is the single most useful thing you can bring.

PREPARING, UNDERSTANDING, REMEMBERING

That is the whole job here. It does not diagnose, and it does not know your parent. Anything it says about a condition or a medication is something to ask a clinician about, not to act on.

Try this now. Write the timeline before the next appointment, not in the waiting room.

07

A trip everyone can live with

Family trips fail on mismatched expectations. Someone wanted rest, someone wanted to see things, someone wanted the children exhausted by four o'clock. Nobody said so out loud, and the disappointment arrives on day two.

Describe the people, not the destination.

BEFORE YOU BOOK ANYTHING

Plan four days for two adults in their sixties who walk well but tire in the afternoon, our daughter and her husband, and two children aged four and nine. One of the adults hates a rigid schedule and one gets anxious without a plan. Give me a shape for each day with gaps in it.

Ask for the conflicts to be named.**THE USEFUL FOLLOW-UP**

Where in this plan are those two adults most likely to fall out, and what would prevent it?

That question is worth more than the itinerary. It surfaces the four o'clock problem before you're standing in it.

Ask for one anchor per day and nothing else fixed. Over-planned family days break on the first delay.

Ask what the children will actually tolerate — an honest answer about attention spans beats an ambitious plan.

Try this now. Describe your family honestly, including the friction, and ask where the plan will break.

08

The admin nobody wants

Forms, school letters, renewals, permission slips, the thing that needs doing before a deadline you've half-noticed.

None of it is difficult. All of it is draining, mostly because it arrives in fragments.

Understand a form before filling it in. *Explain what this is asking for, section by section, and what I'll need to hand before I start.*

Draft the awkward reply. The school letter, the housing form, the thing that needs a firm answer.

Turn a pile into a list. Describe everything outstanding and ask for it ordered by deadline.

Work out what's missing. *What do people usually forget when applying for this?*

THE SUNDAY-EVENING ONE

I'll list everything that's outstanding for the family in no particular order — school things, appointments, renewals, forms. Put it in order of what actually has to happen first, and flag anything that looks like it has a deadline I've missed.

KEEPING THE FAMILY'S RECORDS STRAIGHT

Ask it to write up the things everyone forgets and nobody has written down: which bank, which policy number, who the solicitor was, where the will is, which neighbour has a key. Then put it somewhere the rest of the family can find. Most families discover they needed this at the worst possible moment.

Try this now. Do the Sunday-evening ask. It takes four minutes and clears a surprising amount of low-level dread.

09

What this shouldn't be doing

Worth being clear about, in a book that touches children and elderly parents.

Not deciding anything about your child's education, health, or wellbeing. It can help you prepare for a conversation with a teacher or a doctor. The judgement stays with you and them.

Not replacing a professional. If you're worried about a child's development, an elderly parent's safety, or anyone's mental health, that is a conversation with a person who is qualified and who can actually see the situation.

Not a confidant for your child, unsupervised. Younger children in particular shouldn't be having private conversations with it about anything that matters. Sit with them.

Not a place for other people's private information. Your parent's medical details and your child's difficulties belong to them. Describe the situation rather than pasting the documents, and take the names out.

THE ONE THAT MATTERS MOST

If something in your family is frightening rather than difficult — a child in trouble, a parent who is unsafe, anyone at risk — that is a moment for a person, urgently. Not a better-worded question.

Try this now. Nothing. Read that box twice instead.

The homework helper card

Stick this by the computer where homework happens.

Always say their age. "My nine-year-old" changes the whole explanation.

Always say "a different example." This is the line between tutoring and answering.

Always ask it to question them. "Ask her questions as you go to check she's following."

For checking work: "Tell me what to ask so she finds it herself" — never "correct this."

When they're demoralised: "Start with something he already knows, and be encouraging without being patronising."

The test, afterwards: can they explain it back to you in their own words?

The rule: nothing it writes gets handed in. Ever.

Check the school's policy. Their rules, not this card, are the authority.

When it goes wrong

"It gave my son the answer." You didn't say *a different example* and *don't solve the actual problem*. Both, every time. It defaults to being helpful.

"The explanation went over her head." Give the age and ask for a comparison from something specific she knows — her school, a game she plays, something in the kitchen.

"It was too gentle to be a useful rehearsal." Ask it explicitly to push back, be defensive, or be unreasonable. It will stay agreeable unless told otherwise.

"It suggested something for my mother that worried me." Take it to her doctor. Anything about a condition or a medication is a question to ask a clinician, not an instruction.

"The trip plan was exhausting." It planned for capable adults unless told otherwise. Say the ages, the energy, and the afternoon problem.

"I felt like I was outsourcing parenting." Worth listening to. The uses in this book are meant to help you show up better prepared — with the questions written down, the conversation rehearsed, the explanation ready. If it starts replacing the being-there rather than supporting it, that instinct is right and worth following.

THE PATTERN

Almost every problem here comes from leaving out the person: the child's age, the parent's condition, the teenager's likely reaction. Describe the people and it behaves completely differently.

If you only do one thing

Take one habit and leave the other eight.

Make it ask, rather than tell.

Ask it to question your child instead of explaining at them. Ask it to question you about what you've forgotten in caring for a parent. Ask it to play the teenager rather than advise you about him. Ask it what you should have asked at the appointment.

Everything in this book gets better when the thing is asking questions rather than producing answers — because in family life the answer was almost never the hard part. Working out what's actually going on was.

Do this next

Messages you've been avoiding? → Letters, Emails, and Awkward Messages — including the note to a teacher and the boundary with a relative.

Cautious about what you're typing in? → Is This Safe? — especially relevant here, since this book touches your children's and your parents' private lives.

Want your requests to land first time? → Asking Better Questions — the four things that turn a generic answer into a useful one.

Everything else around the house? → Around the House — dinner, repairs, clutter, quotes.

The Everyday Claude Guides — start where you are.

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